Music posters and album covers in the Psychedelic 1960's era

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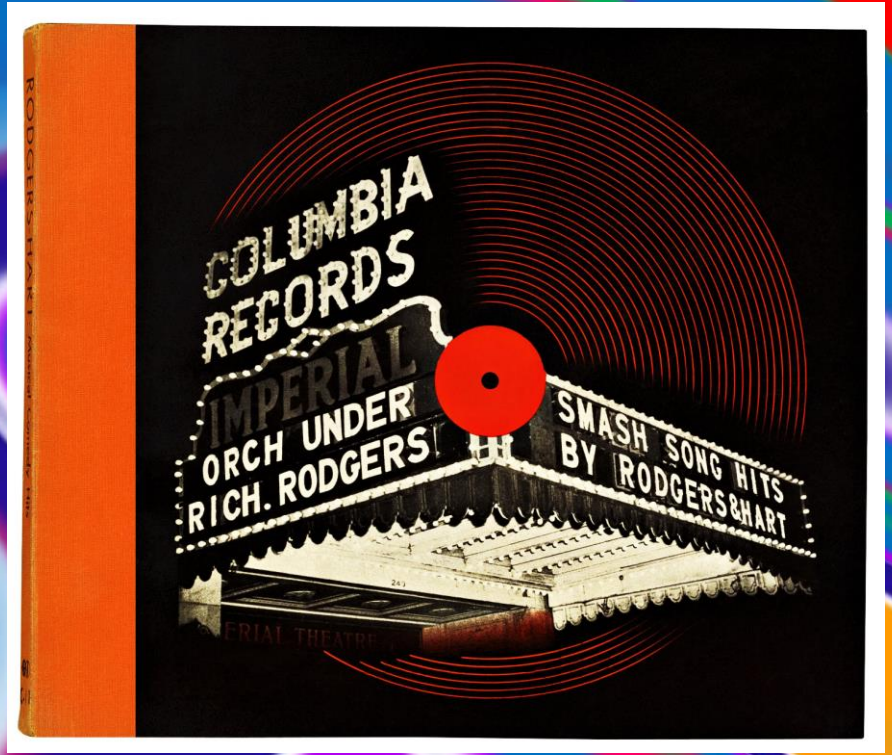
Album Covers – Early Pioneers

- The first hints of innovation appeared in the 1930s
- Alex Steinweiss (1917–2011):
  - His illustrated covers resulted in massive sales surges.
  - persuaded the owner of Imperial Theatre to modify the marquee's signage for a short time.



Smash Song Hits by Rodgers & Hart - first record cover in history (1939).

Album Covers – The Folded-Overboard Sleeve

- record labels began to employ a folded-overboard type sleeve
- artistic creativity

The Rolling Stones Sticky Fingers
(1971)

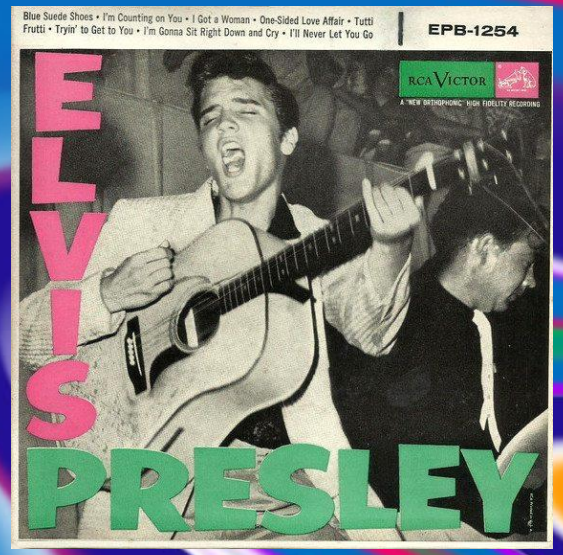
Album Covers – Early Pioneers

- Cover design had a huge cultural impact
- reached millions of people during the glory days of radio
- allowed designers to express their individuality to a global audience
- Andy Warhol, Roger Dean, and Burt Goldblatt got their start designing record covers.

The *Gun's* debut album (1968) was Roger Dean's first music project.

Album Covers – Rock n Roll

- The imagery for many albums derives from film posters
- merely beautiful images with typography.
- "Technicolor photoshopped grins" with full-size photographs of the faces of youthful crooners.

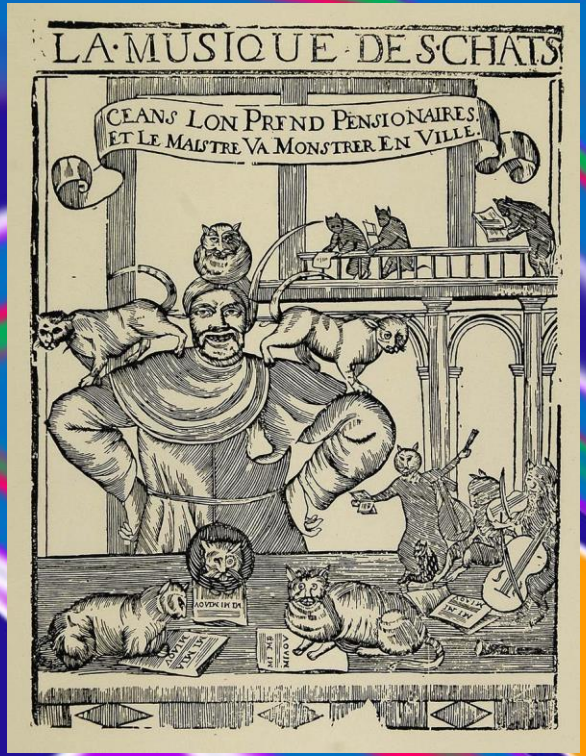


William V "Red" Robertson's shot of Elvis Presley for the RCA album (1956)

Frankie Avalon self-titled album cover (1958)

MUSIC POSTERS – The Discovery of Lithography

- Posters have been around since the discovery of Lithography in 1798.
- Greyscale wood or metal carvings were used in the long and costly procedure.



La Musique des Chats poster (1702)

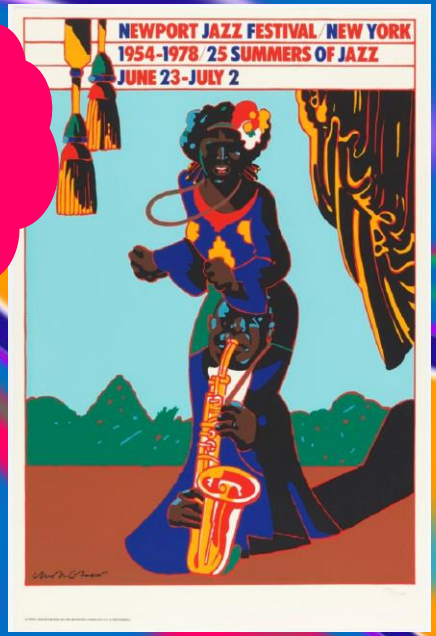
MUSIC POSTERS – Printing in Full Colour

- 1954: Newport Jazz Festival - economical production using paper and plastic as basic materials.
- Founder George Wein printed in full colour

original festival poster from 1954

VS

Milton Glaser's design from 1978



The Discovery of LSD

- The use of drugs to 'alter the state of consciousness' became standard practice
- Music absorbed psychedelic culture to become part of 1960s popular culture

The effects of LSD

The Hippie Movement

- 1960s: the age of "The Hippie Movement"
- represented a fresh wave of social acceptance and rebellion against society's structure and conventions.
- central aim was to establish and follow "Counterculture"
- Art and music were used to portray this theme of exploration

The Civil Rights Movement

- The 60's were dominated by the civil rights movement and the Vietnam war.
- assassinations of John F Kennedy (35th president of the US) and Martin Luther King
- M.L.K. played a lead role in the American civil rights movement.
- He longed for equality and human rights for African Americans, economical disadvantages and all victims of injustice through peaceful protests.

Civil Rights Peaceful Protests

Martin Luther King J.

John F. Kennedy

The Vietnam War and The Cold War

- 1955-1975
- a divisive conflict against the communist government of the North of Vietnam and the South
- intensified by the ongoing Cold War between the US and the Soviet Union.
- began because of lasting tension between the two at the end of *World War II* (1945-1989)

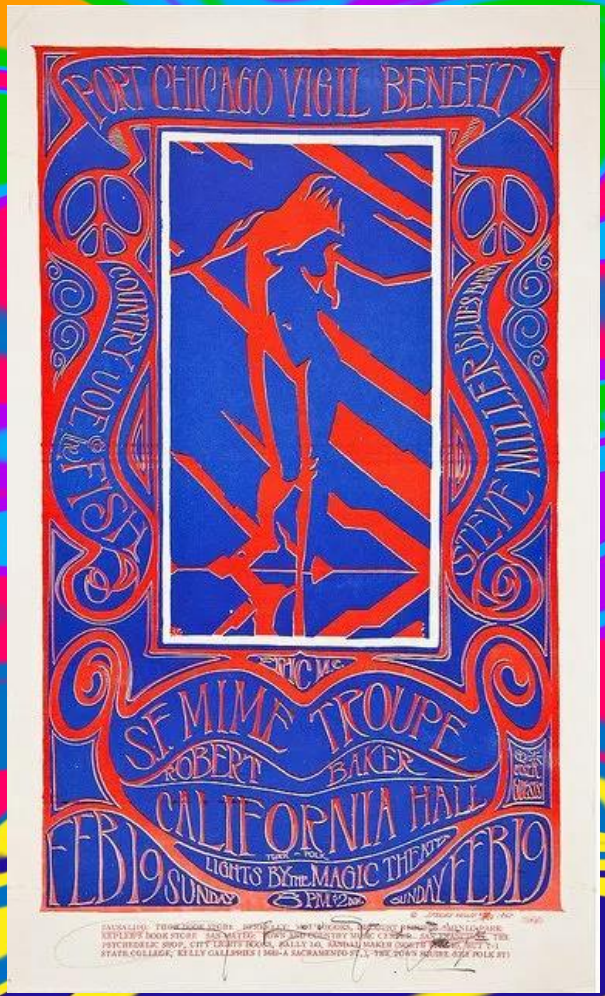
The Vietnam War

The Cold War

MUSIC POSTERS – The Entrance of Psychedelia

- Cater to 'free loving' and purity of art in music, representing the mellow and grooving essence of the bands it represents
- lava lamp-like typography and organic forms reveal the subtext that lies underneath the music

Poster for *The Grateful Dead* by Wes Wilson titled
'Otis Rush & His Chicago Blues Band' (1967)



This 1966 *Avalon Ballroom* first print poster is
on white vellum

Psychedelia-Inspired Rock Musicians

Numerous rock musicians began to create psychedelic albums in the 1960s, and psychedelic-rock quickly became a popular genre

Psychedelic Rock bands- The 13th Floor Elevators

- The *13th Floor Elevators* were one of the pioneering bands of psychedelic music.
- Many expressed that they were the first true psychedelic rock band.

- John Lennon's vinyl album *Menlove Ave* (1986)
- Andy Warhol made this startling portrait shortly after John Lennon's death in 1980.

- *The Doors* 1967 Washington poster
- *The Doors* ended up as one of the most mind-blowing Psychedelic-Rock bands ever in the history of Rock music.

- Pink Floyd with Procol harem & H.P Lovecraft poster by Bill Graham
- Pink Floyd became one of the leading forces behind 1960s psychedelia.
- The lyrics of the band have been described as "biting political, social, and emotional commentary."

1970-1989

The International Typographic Style spread beyond Switzerland rapidly and became the leading graphic design style worldwide in the '70s.

Wolfgang Weingart music poster designed by Das Kunstlerische Werk (1982)

The Punk-Rock Era

- Punk-Rock is a style of music that first gained popularity in the mid-70s, right after the psychedelic era.
- The term "punk rock" was created in the 1960s to describe garage artists.
- Punk is defined by its aggressive and modern aesthetic and vibe.
- Characteristics of Punk typography:
  - Inconsistent letterspacing
  - Varying type weights within single words

The Clash – The Clash (album cover 1977)

Ramones – Road to Ruin (album cover 1978)

Differences between psychedelic music and punk rock music

Punk-Rock

- Use of collages, cartoon drawings, hand-lettering,
- rub-down lettering, ransom-note lettering, stencils.
- Each design was made with the purpose of challenging and breaking modern culture's norms.

Psychedelia

- Bright intense colours
- swirling patterns
- optical illusions
- illegible hand-drawn typefaces
- highly stylized.

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